government had no place to hide. Much of the opprobrium was deserved, some of it was hyped. The CAG said the country had lost Rs 1.76 lakh crore in spectrum allocation; we believed it, almost uncritically. We screamed ‘scam’ every time the Opposition told us there was one. Maybe this is an inevitable fallout of a media ecosystem where noise replaces news and sensation takes over from sense.

Or maybe it’s just the nature of the beast that is twenty-four-hour news TV which simply gets carried away by the surround sound. Nearly every rally or public event of Modi got live coverage, in a manner that smacked of the herd mentality which bedevils contemporary news TV. One channel would air it, the rest would quickly follow. We even dropped advertising breaks for a Modi rally. On one particular day, Modi had four rallies. We had shown two of them live. I suggested that we need not air the third because it was getting repetitive. Five minutes later, I saw the rally was being telecast. ‘Sir, everyone is showing it, we should be showing it too,’ was the response in the newsroom. A colleague was even more direct. ‘Modi is TRP boss!’

Just how far we were willing to play along with the Modi agenda was reflected in the controversy over the release of the BJP manifesto. The manifesto release coincided with the first day of polling when parts of the north-east, including Assam, were voting. The BJP officially insists they did not deliberately target a voting day but that the manifesto exercise was ‘delayed’ because Modi was unhappy with the lengthy booklet originally prepared by a team headed by senior leader Murli Manohar Joshi.

Twenty-four hours before the release, there had been an intense debate amongst news channel heads whether we should be telecasting the manifesto release live while voting was on, since it might be seen as a violation of the election code. ‘Can you please check this for us?’ Shazi Zaman, the head of the News Broadcasters Association, asked me.

I rang up the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC), V.S. Sampath, to get an official view. He promised to get back after seeking legal opinion. A little after 11 p.m., he rang up to say that ‘The manifesto release could be shown in all parts of India, except those where voting was taking place.’ I